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WHAT IS HAPPENING AT GRAFENECK ASYLUM?

SOURCE INVESTIGATION

It is 1940. You live near an asylum for the mentally handicapped at Grafeneck in south-west Germany. The local people face a problem. There are more and more rumours about what is happening at the asylum. Here is some of the evidence that locals are talking about. Can you make sense of it?

1. Why did the Nazis make the film *I accuse*?
2. Which other piece of evidence best helps explain the purpose of the film?
3. Is there enough evidence to prove what the asylum was being used for?
4. If not, what other evidence would be useful?

A The asylum at Grafeneck



B There is smoke all the time from the chimney of the crematorium.

C Grey vans of the Postal Transport Service, full of people, some of whom are in straightjackets or handcuffs, now enter the asylum much more frequently than they used to. I have not yet seen them bring anyone out.



E Many families with relatives in the asylum are receiving letters of condolences such as this one:

Today the asylum accounting office received your credit transfer of twenty Reichmarks intended for flowers for the grave of your little daughter Irmgard. We can report that Irmgard was still overjoyed with the little coat, and above all with the lovely dolly, which she had in her arms to the very end.

F Some staff at the asylum drink in the local inn and when drunk have suggested their work is most unusual and make sick jokes about the quality of local fertilisers.

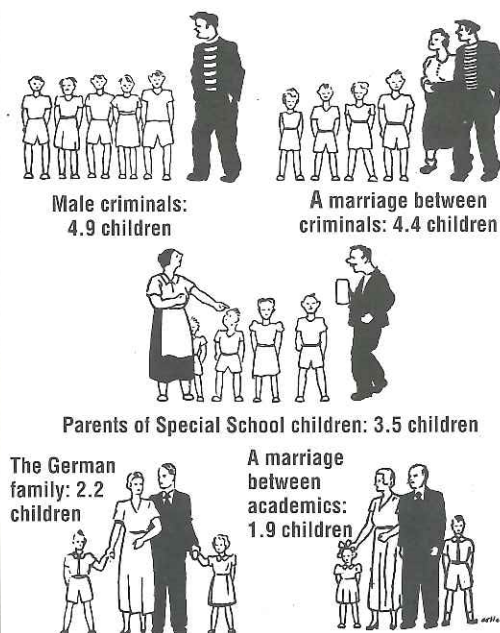
D Families with relatives in the asylum have been informed of their deaths, but odd things have happened such as:

- One family received two urns of ashes for one dead relative
- Hairpins have turned up in the ashes of males
- People who had their appendix removed years before have been declared dead due to appendicitis
- Parents who have removed their children from the asylum have received a letter notifying them of their death
- Families have put death notices in newspapers such as:

...his sudden death will always remain a mystery to us.

G You remember this cartoon which appeared in 1938 claiming the fertility rates of the criminal and educationally backward were higher than the 'ideal German family'.

The Menace of the Subhumans



J Someone told you about a speech Hitler made in 1929 in which he said:

If Germany was to remove 700,000-800,000 of the weakest people then the final result might be an increase in strength.



ACTIVITY

Work in groups of four. Either role-play or write a short conversation that might take place in the home of a family living in Grafeneck. One member of the family should be pro-Nazi; another anti-Nazi; the other two should be undecided about the Nazis.

In your conversation use the evidence on this page and your wider knowledge of Nazi policies.

H A new film called *I accuse* has been released. The hero is a medical professor whose young wife Hanna suffers from multiple sclerosis. When he fails to find a cure, he decides to kill her with an overdose to end her suffering. He is accused of murder, there is a big court case and he is found innocent.

A scene from *I accuse*. Professor Heyt comforts his wife Hanna whom he is about to kill.



I The Nazis are encouraging everyone to see the film. The local Catholic priest is against your seeing it. Other films you have seen tell about the cost of keeping people in asylums.

K In 1940 Heinrich Himmler, head of the SS, wrote to an official concerning the asylum at Grafeneck:



The population recognises the grey vans of the SS and believes it knows what is going on in the perpetually smoking crematorium. What is happening there is supposed to be secret, but it is not any more. Because of this, the mood there is very ugly. In my opinion, the only alternative is to cease employing the asylum in this way, and, if need be, to enlighten people there intelligently and rationally, by allowing films to be shown about the hereditarily and mentally ill.